

IAT 210 – Board Game Pre-Production Prototype

Unawaken Crown – Game Dynamics

Abstract

This section examines the dominant player strategies, recurring gameplay patterns, and emergent interactions observed during the playtesting of Unawaken Crown. Rather than describing the game's individual mechanics (which can be mistaken for the game-dynamics), the focus is specifically around how those mechanics combined to influence player behaviour and which strategies consistently proved effective.

As Unawaken Crown is a prototype, playtesting was limited to smaller group samples, often for only single play sessions. To supplement this, additional testing was performed using computer-simulated players to generate larger datasets; this allowed for a better way to identify recurring gameplay trends and strategic play behaviours. This section summarizes the dynamics that emerged most consistently across both physical and simulated playtests.

Observable Player Dynamics:

- **Opportunistic Path Rushing & Conflict Avoidance**

- Unawaken Crown includes a variety of alternative ways to finish a game. Despite players initially playing more aggressively and attacking each other often, eventually players found they could reach the **ordinary ending** more easily without conflict, by rushing through their path deck. This was a common strategy, forgoing typical intentionally aggressive playstyles and relying only on path clearance to ensure the quickest victory.
- The **wake up** ending typically took longer to achieve for players and was achieved less frequently; however, it gave way to a more balanced playstyle, with players having a good mixture of offensive and defensive play, as well as consistent path clearing. Computer-controlled players used this more defensive playstyle more frequently than human players, who relied more on conflict avoidance.

- **Limited Diplomacy**

- Due to the nature of achieving the **real ending**, which allows for a player to choose a shared ending for all players, cooperation and diplomacy (such as trading cards) was rather limited. Since the real ending requires obtaining the three symbol cards by event chance, diplomacy was often skipped in favor of either attacking other players or rushing through path cards to achieve an ending.

Emergent Playstyles and Player Archetypes:

- **Aggressive Conquest**
 - As with most games with combat mechanics, certain players would tend to lean toward a more aggressive “defeat all other players” style, even if said playstyle was actually less effective. Such players were typically the last to achieve certain endings.
- **Strategic Partners**
 - While infrequent, cooperative play was not entirely absent. Certain players created pre-aligned teams with one another, with the intent of either achieving solo endings without conflict or attempting to reach the more abstract real ending.
- **Ordinary Ending Rusher**
 - As mentioned briefly in the previous section, many players would rush through path cards in order to obtain an ending as quickly as possible. Conflict was usually avoided in favor of speedrunning to the end

Systemic Resource Economies & Feedback Loops:

- **Intentional HP Sacrifice**
 - A surprising element of Unawaken Crown was that players would paradoxically choose cards or event outcomes that would result in minimal-major HP loss. Despite the seemingly negative effects of such methods, players often benefited in the longer run in achieving certain endings and obtaining symbolic cards.
- **Attention Usage**
 - Due to the recurring attention replenishing at the start of each round (which can be modified through card effects), there was no reason for players to save attention across turns. However, the order in which players used their attention points within the confines of a single turn mattered significantly. Since a lot of player choices and events can occur in a single turn, players who effectively managed their attention points could chain a series of cards and affect events through certain attention requiring choices. Different playstyles were linked carefully to how players used their attention throughout an individual turn.

Ending Outcomes:

- **Ordinary Ending, Wake-Up Ending, Real Ending**

- Lastly, this section briefly discusses the frequency of endings in more detail. The previous segments dived into the player psychology and play strategies. After compiling certain playtest metrics, the division between endings roughly equated to: *65% Ordinary Ending, 30% Wake Up Ending, 5% Real Ending.*
- These are loose estimates, but they are consistent with the player behavioral strategies discussed earlier. Ending frequency correlates heavily to the various playstyles and player archetypes.